

Appendix

CHAPTER ZERO

THE REAR-VIEW MIRROR

CENTENNIAL CLUTTER OF ESTEEMED BIASES

As the introduction of this book argues, the historiography of 1857 was challenged for the first time in 1908 by Veer Savarkar. He questioned the motivations of the 'partial and prejudiced' Victorian historians and made a strong case for a significant reassessment of the events of 1857.

Savarkar was pointing out the obvious. The English version of history was predictably Anglo-centric. It would have been naïve to assume that the victors of the War would even attempt to present an unbiased history of the subject.

In 1957, ten years after India's independence, as India observed the centennial year of the War, there was a renewed interest in the historiography of 1857. This was going to be the first time after securing political freedom that Indian historians had an opportunity to reassess the events that took place in 1857.

Logic would have dictated that Indian historians would have attempted to eliminate the biases of the English historians. However, Bentinck's attack on Indic education and the 'reforms' that followed, seemed to have successfully overridden logic. Four generations after 'native' languages were

marginalised in favor of English – the English educated and speaking class that Macaulay was proud of, was stupendously successful in defending the English history books written in the nineteenth century. India had secured political freedom, but the intellectuals remained in chains.

Two 'authorative' books on 1857 were published in 1957. The first by S.N. Sen and a second by R.C. Majumdar. They represent the dominant logic that was expressed in 1957, which was not only a continuation of the 'partial and prejudiced' history; it had more venom, considering it was written by Indians. As Marxists ideals took root in India, the biases changed with time. Historians continued to marginalise the leadership of 1857 with the focus more on the 'subaltern' elements of the War. The 'sepoy mutiny' became a 'civil rebellion' but the revisionist elements stayed the same. Savarkar's underlying thesis remained largely ignored.

The following is a short review of the two books written in 1957 by Sen and Majumdar.

OFFICIALLY PEJORATIVE, VENOMOUS AND CLUELESS

S.N. Sen, *Eighteen Fifty-Seven*, by, 1957

What was considered to be the 'official' history of 1857 was written by Surendra Nath Sen, a former Head of Department of History, Calcutta University and vice-chancellor of Delhi University from 1950 to 1953, in a book titled *Eighteen Fifty-Seven*, published by the Publications Division, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting in 1957.

His conclusions were in line with those of the British historians, that the events of 1857 did not characterise as a nationalist uprising, and ignores evidence suggesting that there was any planning involved in any form but were, at best, an 'inevitable mutiny'.

Sen arbitrarily dismisses pieces of the evidence that indicated some level of leadership or planning in these events. Sen marginalises the proclamation made by Bahadur Shah and copies of which were circulated and posted in many places including Delhi. Sen writes, the proclamation 'purporting to come from the Shah (Bahadur), it is true, was once displayed at the Jami Masjid...' and goes on to suggest instead that 'the paper in question' must have come from an 'individual' or an 'ordinary citizen' instead.¹ He also

summarily dismisses the popularity of the proclamation by claiming that, 'it went unnoticed by the general public in Delhi'. We are uncertain what scientific techniques or results of surveys and polls he used to reach this conclusion about the 'popularity' of this proclamation.

The general tone of the narrative is consistent with English accounts. In describing the situations during war, we find Mr. Sen in the 'enemy' camp – sympathising with their day-to-day issues and concerns, distant from the happenings on the 'other' side with Indian soldiers.

He acknowledges that the story of the 'chapatis lend some colour to the theory or prior preparation, propaganda and conspiracy'. However, is quick in dismissing it saying, 'a conspiracy is not conducted through such an unintelligible and uncertain medium of communication'. He goes on to quote Syed Ahmed, knighted by the English Queen, who concluded 'The fact is that even at the present day we do not know what caused the distribution of those chuppaties'.

Sen's conclusions can be succinctly paraphrased to mean, 'because, none of us historians have a clue about the meaning behind these chapati incidents, we are going to ignore this evidence completely'. The incidents of the Red Lotus flowers making rounds of the garrisons have no mention in his conclusions that were officially published by the Indian Ministry of Information and Broadcasting in 1957. Fortunately, after nearly 150 years, we have discovered the planning and the mystery and the meaning behind these chapati and lotus incidents and were presented in preceding chapters.

Perhaps the greatest irony of this book is that it was published in a free India, by the Indian Government, ruled by Indians, but this esteemed Indian historian actually indicates the plausible planning by Indian leaders (which he summarily dismisses) that went into the war of 1857 as a 'conspiracy'.

A conspiracy!

A quick look at the dictionary reveals the following meaning:

con-spir-a-cy [kuhn-spir-uh-see]: an evil, unlawful, treacherous, or surreptitious plan formulated in secret by two or more persons; plot.²

Did India in 1957, ten years after it was free, 'officially' consider that any plan to overthrow the English in 1857 was an 'evil, unlawful and a treacherous plan'?

THE MISSING NATION

R.C. Majumdar, *The Sepoy Mutiny and the Revolt of 1857*, 1957

Ramesh Chandra Majumdar was born in 1888. Not unlike other children who were the product of Macaulay's educational reforms, his skills in the English language combined with due display of loyalty, earned him some important positions during the British rule, including vice-chancellor of Dacca University. The English continued to honour him and made him an honorary fellow of the Asiatic Society of Great Britain and Ireland. He was also an honorary fellow of the Asiatic Societies of Calcutta and Bombay. He was also the vice-president of the International Commission for History of the Scientific and Cultural Development of Mankind set up by UNESCO. Majumdar was certainly a historian admired by the English and the West.

The central thesis of Majumdar's argument can be reduced to one simple question – How can there be a war, if there wasn't even a nation? In Majumdar's opinion that is consistent with western ideas of a nation, India did not even exist as a nation until the twentieth century.

In any case, a War is not necessarily an armed conflict only between nations. It could be between nations, states or any two parties. Eighteen fifty-seven was a war, yet Majumdar and others, use semantics to diminish and dismiss the battle for survival of a civilisation over five thousand years old with a strong self-identity, using misplaced western arguments and ideas.

R.C. Majumdar summarised the events of 1857 as, 'purely a mutiny of the sepoys, joined at a later stage by some discontented elements as well as the riff-raff and other disturbing elements of society'. One would assume that he was implying that the Rani of Jhansi was amongst the 'discontented elements'. Does that make Tatya Topé, Azimullah Khan and others the 'riff-raff'? Or did the 'riff-raff' include the ordinary brave Indians and villagers who supported this war? Surely, the British did not expect the commoners to show exemplary bravery; perhaps, neither do Indian historians such as Majumdar. Perhaps Majumdar and others were dismissing and therefore diminishing various roles, discouraging further study on these areas.

What we describe in this book as the Anglo-Indian War of 1857 signified the coming together of the two greatest Indian empires that existed in the eighteenth century as rivals, the Mughals through Bahadur Shah and the

Marathas through Nana Saheb. Majumdar gets very personal in his criticism of these two men.

Nana Saheb, the adopted son of Bajirao II, was one of the important leaders in the planning and economic support of this war. Majumdar in the footsteps of British historians resorts to name calling, but it is not Nana Saheb's character that he demolishes – but that of his father who adopted him, calling Nana Saheb 'the son of a worthless wicked ex-Peshwa'. Bajirao II died in 1851 and had nothing to do with the events of 1857. We are still uncertain why Majumdar chose to write these words in relation to Nana Saheb. Perhaps he was simply continuing the tradition of English historians in denouncing all the Indian leaders, in any form or fashion, who led the war against the British.

In contrast, we have to assume that Mr Majumdar was generous in his description of Bahadur Shah, calling him only a 'dotard', picking on him for his age and alleged senility and not his ancestry. Majumdar's writings seems to indicate that he was upset that Bahadur Shah, who was supposed to be a 'puppet in the throne', to have actually dared to rise against the British.

You would hardly expect a scholarly historian to resort to name-calling using words like 'wicked', 'worthless' and 'dotard'. While Majumdar's qualifications are not in question his tone betrays a predetermined agenda.

Majumdar's conclusions are consistent with those of the British historians; however, he goes further to suggest that describing these events, as a 'war' would be tantamount to acknowledging that India was ever a 'nation', before 1857. If by Majumdar's definition, 'India' did not exist as a nation or a country, before 1857, we wonder why he did not criticise the English for naming a very important company inaccurately at its inception. Perhaps, if R.C. Majumdar was alive on 31 December 1600, he would have called the English East India Company a name which would have been consistent with his opinion of India before the arrival of the British: 'The English, South Asian Peninsular Collection of Multiple and Disparate Kingdoms, Company' instead.

Born at a time in a nation whose existence he does not acknowledge; ironically, R.C. Majumdar has been called by some as, 'one of the greatest of Indian historians'.

GHOSTS IN THE MACHINE

There are many classifications that exist for fallacious arguments. In the context of history, these classifications become more complex since there are many other factors to consider. Historians, especially relative to 1857 have had a licence to distort. We have attempted to bring order into that chaos of historical equivocations, lies and damned lies (but not statistics). We consider that history is presented on two distinct dimensions, the first that is based on factual presentation and second based on the completeness of the facts and logical rigor. Coherent history is narrated when complete facts are presented in a logical manner.

Based on what and how narratives are presented, we can classify them as Stories, Myths, Noise, and Coherent History, as shown in the figure below. Unlike commonly believed, narrating history is not simply a serialising a sequence of dates and facts. Since the editorial selection of facts can present a distorted view of events – this can be described as ‘noise’ in history. The argumentative fallacies that fall into this category are omissions, trivialisations

and oversimplifications – whereby it is still possible to present only facts – yet still be fallacious.

Similarly, history is different than just narrating a story – where the narrator has the freedom to create characters and events. Inventions and equivocations in history would fall into this quadrant. Neither is history about propagating myths. Where certain ambiguous ‘facts’ are used to create illogical implications and then indefinitely repeated, until the other historian start believing them to be factual. Often

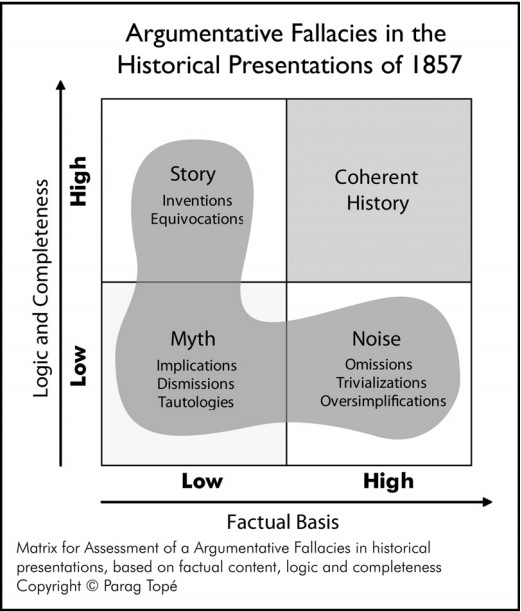


Figure 65: Argumentative Fallacies

important evidence is dismissed to support these ‘myths’. History is unique because the writers of history have a significant amount of freedom to narrate events and information based on facts. History can be distorted by presenting only partial facts; which when read would sound factually accurate – but still does not accurately represent the events.

The events of 1857 have been told to us in almost every form. Some are pure inventions. Some stories are only partial presentations of facts. Some stories are regurgitated so often, that they have reached the status of mythological presentation.

Unfortunately, there’s a dearth of finding anything that would fall into this category of coherent history. The history of the events of 1857 as presented to us is full of inventions, omissions, trivialisations, dismissions, dutiful yet meaningless repetitions, wrongful implications, equivocations and oversimplifications.

The ability of historians to muddle around these quadrants is dictated by their ability to manipulate the system that defines what is acceptable. Conversely, sometimes even the system allows and encourages distorted mirrors and blurred lenses.

In his book, *The Concept of Mind*, written in 1949, Gilbert Ryle’s described the dualism of the mind and body as presented by René Descartes’ as ‘The ghost in the machine’. In the context of presenting history, we also come across a duality of sorts. The duality of the ‘attitude’ and the ‘aptitude’ in presenting history.

The machinery that defines India’s history is run by these ghosts of misalignment. We express no opinion about British historians in this context – since they fall into a completely different system, one where the fundamental approach to India is inverted. However, Indian historians – especially when it comes to representation of the events of 1857 are a misaligned lot.

Historians, who claim to have the rigour and knowledge, and the support of the system, unfortunately view India’s past with jaundiced and almost colonial eyes. We describe this of history as the ‘Pejorative’ history. Then there is the bulk of books who simply use derision to demonise Indian heroes and the events – although it is not considered ‘rigorous’ these books still fill up a large amount of shelf space (the size of which would have made Macaulay proud) associated with the events of 1857. In addition to these, we have many Indian historians who have the right attitude and approach

and tend to view the events without the preexisting prejudices displayed by the Pejorative and the Derisive historians. They attempt to filter through the haze of colonial misrepresentation of history, however, are unable to extricate honest introspection from self-flagellation.

Which leaves a big void, where exists the quadrant of plain, unbiased and objective history. The history of 1857, despite the hundreds of voluminous books that have been written about it, is still remains a vacuum.

FACES OF FREEDOM

The War of 1857 was led by leaders such as Nana Saheb, Bahadur Shah and Tatya Tope. We call them the 'leonine leaders'. The 'pragmatic patriots, like Baija Bai Shinde, supported them. Certainly, 1857 had its share of the 'two-timing traitors' as well the 'waffling weasels'. These, we have argued did not have significant impact on the outcome of the War.

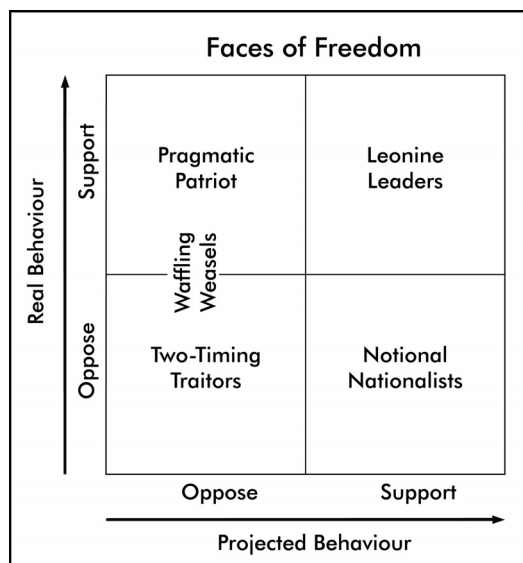


Figure 66: Argumentative Fallacies

However, a fourth category of Indians emerged in the twentieth century who refused to acknowledge that sacrifices of people like Nana Saheb and Tatya Tope were for India, the nation. They attempted to define India through a European lens. They professed to be representing the cause of the Indian nation, but their actions demonstrated otherwise.

By expropriating the credit for India's liberation in the 1940s, they were able to sustain policies that continued

to erode India's social fabric and personal freedom. They used the power of the state for the decades after 1947, to redefine and weaken the Indic identity through a rigid framework controlling all areas of academic thought. We call them the 'notional nationalists'. In the decades following India's